The Indian economy will undergo a seismic shift with the rise of Artificial Intelligence. It is a powerful technological force that will reshape existing business models and craft new ones. Projections indicate that AI will inject an incredible $967 billion into the Indian economy by 2035. As we embark on this new AI dawn, several novel job roles will emerge in the economy, while also overshadowing many that were previously fundamental.

The World Economic Forum's 'Future of Jobs' report delivers an engaging projection for the global job market, predicting substantial changes in nearly a quarter of existing jobs worldwide. According to the report, about 75 per cent of the companies surveyed are set to embrace AI, presaging a significant reshaping of the job market.

Impressively, half of these organisations anticipate that integrating AI will lead to considerable job creation. This trend is further substantiated by a recent survey in India involving over a thousand employers. In this survey, an overwhelming 85 per cent of organisations anticipate that AI will not only create new jobs within the next 1-5 years but also enhance the quality of existing roles. Furthermore, 77 per cent of employers are optimistic that AI will improve job security and foster career development. This positive outlook is echoed by the workforce, with many job-seekers expecting AI to streamline work efficiency, facilitate skill development, enable a focus on more complex tasks and emphasise skill-based hiring over experience-centric recruitment.

However, it is critical to acknowledge that the job market is confronted with a significant challenge in its march towards scientific and technological excellence: a pronounced gap between the industry's evolving demands and the present state of STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, Mathematics) education and skill development. The increase in the number of STEM graduates does not align with their employability, with a notable deficiency in the quality of talent. In line with the prime minister's ambitious vision for India to emerge as a developed nation by 2047, a radical overhaul in skill development is imperative. This transformation involves adapting the workforce to align with the global labour market, focusing on skills pertinent to Industry 4.0 and the competencies required for future technological advancements. By the year 2030, India is projected to have a working age population of one billion, accounting for a fourth of the global increase in workforce over the next decade. Harnessing this demographic potential to shape and contribute to the new technological landscape is essential for India to realise its aspirations of development and global prominence.

The Indian job market will need a diverse range of specialised talent. This will entail technical proficiency in product management, backend and frontend development, full-stack capabilities, data science, AI/ML, cyber security, software reliability and UI/UX design. Additionally, expertise in cloud service platforms, cloud application development, DevOps and Big Data will increasingly become vital. Moreover, there will be escalating demand for domain-specific skills in emerging areas like Web3, AR/VR, IoT, climate tech, agri-science and biosciences.

Addressing the skills gap requires a holistic and multifaceted strategy, much of which is advocated by the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020. Aligning educational programmes with current skill demands, including the establishment of 'Future Schools' specialising in sunrise sectors like synthetic biology, is key to preparing the next generation of tech professionals in India. This should include the implementation of skill- and practice-based learning and the establishment of multidisciplinary education and research universities to achieve international standards in teaching and research. Concurrently, major

TAKEAWAYS

- Projections indicate that AI will inject $967 billion into the Indian economy by 2035
- In a survey involving over a thousand employers, 85 per cent of the organisations predicted that AI will create new jobs in the next 1-5 years and enhance existing roles
- There is an urgent need to nurture an array of essential skills beyond technical proficiency to build adaptability in the workforce

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